

■ SOUTHERN LATITUDES

The view south is packed with stars. Due south are the constellations Carina and Vela. The white supergiant Canopus marks the western end of Carina. At magnitude −0.62, Canopus is second only to Sirius, the brightest star of all. Sirius is above and west of Canopus. Eta (η) Carinae is a variable star that brightens considerably when it erupts. In 1841, it rivaled Sirius after a giant outburst of material.

The southeastern sky is dominated by the two bright stars Alpha (α) and Beta (β) Centauri, which point to the nearby tiny constellation of Crux. Farther east, the first of the winter constellations are rising above the eastern horizon. Virgo is leading the way, followed by Scorpius.

Due north is Leo. Its stars draw out a crouching lion, which southern-hemisphere observers see upside-down. The lion is apparently lying on its back with its head facing west; its bright star Regulus, marking the start of an outstretched front paw, is above. Almost equidistant and at either side of

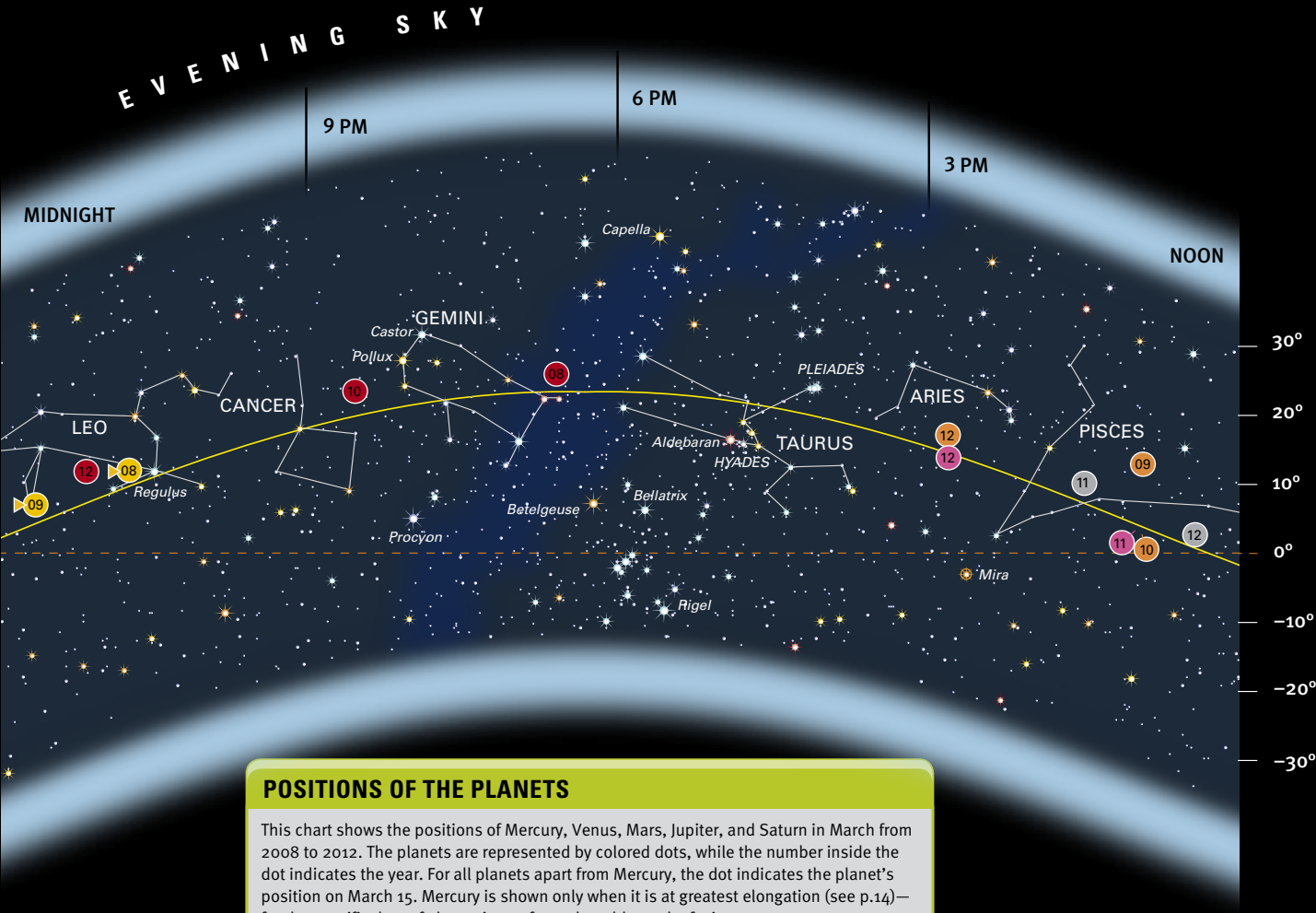
Regulus are two equally bright stars: to the west, Procyon in Canis Minor; and to the east, Spica in Virgo. Closer to the eastern horizon is the red giant Arcturus and the constellation Boötes, a forerunner of the winter sky to come. On the opposite side of the sky, the summer constellation of Orion can be seen disappearing over the western horizon.



Eta Carinae Nebula
The fuzzy red object at right is the Eta Carinae Nebula (NGC 3372). Embedded within is the variable star Eta Carinae. To its left is Crux and the dark nebula the Coalsack, which is blocking the light of more distant stars.



Leo, the lion
The recognizable figure Leo is seen in this northern-sky view. The bright star at lower right is Regulus. The curve of stars that make up his shoulders and head extend up from Regulus. Denebola, the bright star at lower left, marks the start of the lion's tail. Turn the book upside-down to see how Leo appears in the southern sky.



POSITIONS OF THE PLANETS

This chart shows the positions of Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter, and Saturn in March from 2008 to 2012. The planets are represented by colored dots, while the number inside the dot indicates the year. For all planets apart from Mercury, the dot indicates the planet's position on March 15. Mercury is shown only when it is at greatest elongation (see p.14) — for the specific date of elongation, refer to the table on the facing page.

● Mercury ● Venus ● Mars ● Jupiter ● Saturn

EXAMPLES

●09 Mars's position on March 15, 2009

▶09 Saturn's position on March 15, 2009. The arrow indicates that the planet is in retrograde motion (see p.14)